1. Observation Field Declaration

Phenomenon being analysed.
This case study examines Brexit as a long-duration political, economic, constitutional, and cultural event: the United Kingdom's 2016 decision to leave the European Union, the negotiations and legal settlements that followed, the implementation of the Trade and Cooperation Agreement and the Windsor Framework, and the ongoing consequences visible through early 2026. The object is not "Brexit" as a single act, but Brexit as an evolving field of interpretation in which the same empirical world is repeatedly processed into different truths. The official referendum result was 51.9% Leave to 48.1% Remain, but the interpretive struggle did not end with the count; it migrated into arguments about democratic authority, economic performance, constitutional integrity, identity, and state capacity.

Temporal frame.
The operative period runs from the referendum campaign and vote in 2016 through the end of the transition period in 2020, the trade and regulatory settlement from 2021 onward, the Windsor Framework implementation through 2025, and the UK-EU "reset" efforts visible in 2025–26. The analysis therefore covers both event and afterlife: campaign rhetoric, institutional redesign, trade frictions, migration change, territorial strain, and retrospective public judgment.

Geographic scope.
The primary geographic scope is the United Kingdom, but the phenomenon is intrinsically multi-scalar. It includes Great Britain, Northern Ireland's unique post-Brexit settlement, the UK-EU relationship, and the differentiated territorial politics of Scotland. It also includes the distinction between EU and non-EU trade and migration flows, because Brexit's meaning is frequently narrated through whether the UK has become more globally open, more regionally constrained, or both at once. **Why this phenomenon produces interpretive divergence.**
Brexit produces unusually intense divergence because it sits at the intersection of incompatible evaluative logics. One grammar treats the key question as whether democratic sovereignty was restored; another asks whether institutional and economic interdependence was damaged; another asks who gained, who lost, and how social blocs were reorganised. Each grammar admits many of the same signals, but ranks them differently, explains them through different causal chains, and permits different closures. A 4% long-run productivity loss assumption is decisive in one grammar and secondary in another; a negative EU net migration figure is proof of regained border control in one grammar and evidence of labour-market reconfiguration in another; the Windsor Framework is either pragmatic repair, constitutional compromise, or elite management of a distributional rupture. **Major interpretive communities.**
The principal communities are not just party-political camps. They include sovereigntist constitutionalists and democratic-populists; economists, business groups, civil servants, and institutional analysts focused on market access and administrative friction; and class/distributional interpreters drawing from political economy, regional inequality analysis, labour-market restructuring, and cultural cleavage research. Overlaying these are territorial communities in Scotland and Northern Ireland, where Brexit is processed not simply as UK policy but as a test of union legitimacy and constitutional settlement. Public-attitude research shows that Brexit is entangled with different conceptions of national identity, protectionism, and governance, while trust measures suggest that judgments of Brexit now travel through wider assessments of political competence and integrity.

2. Signal Set

Below is the shared signal field: empirical inputs that are available, documentable, and citable across competing communities.

Signal 1: Referendum result (2016).
Description: Leave won 51.9% to 48.1%, with 17.41 million votes for Leave and 16.14 million for Remain.
Source: Electoral Commission.
Type: quantitative / institutional.

Signal 2: Post-2025 GDP trajectory.
Description: UK nominal GDP rose 0.6% in Q4 2025 and was 4.2% higher than a year earlier, indicating continued growth but not resolving the counterfactual question of Brexit's drag.
Source: ONS GDP first quarterly estimate, Oct–Dec 2025.
Type: quantitative. **Signal 3: Official long-run Brexit drag assumption.**
Description: The OBR's March 2025 forecast framework continues to assume that the post-Brexit UK-EU trading relationship reduces long-run productivity by 4% relative to remaining in the EU.
Source: Office for Budget Responsibility.
Type: institutional / quantitative model-based. **Signal 4: Trade share with the EU in 2024.**
Description: In 2024, UK exports of goods and services to the EU were £358 billion, 41% of all UK exports; imports from the EU were £454 billion, 51% of all imports.
Source: House of Commons Library, using official trade statistics.
Type: quantitative. **Signal 5: Late-2025 trade pattern EU vs non-EU.**
Description: In December 2025, exports to the EU were lower than exports to non-EU countries, while imports from the EU remained higher than imports from non-EU countries.
Source: ONS UK trade, December 2025.
Type: quantitative. **Signal 6: Net migration composition after Brexit.**
Description: In the year ending June 2025, non-EU+ net migration was +383,000, EU+ net migration was -70,000, and British net migration was -109,000.
Source: ONS long-term international migration, provisional YE June 2025.
Type: quantitative / behavioural. **Signal 7: Immigration level and direction.**
Description: Total long-term immigration in YE June 2025 was 898,000, down from 1.299 million a year earlier; non-EU arrivals drove the pattern.
Source: ONS migration bulletin.
Type: quantitative. **Signal 8: EU migration reversal.**
Description: Since 2022, more EU citizens have left the UK than arrived; net EU migration in YE June 2025 was -70,000, and EU immigration is more than 80% below 2016 levels.
Source: Migration Observatory, based on ONS data.
Type: quantitative / behavioural. **Signal 9: Northern Ireland protocol evolution.**
Description: The Windsor Framework, agreed in 2023 and implemented in stages into 2025, redesigned movement of goods, parcels, medicines, VAT, and governance arrangements to reduce frictions created by the original Protocol.
Source: GOV.UK; Northern Ireland Assembly timeline.
Type: institutional. **Signal 10: Scottish independence opinion.**
Description: Polling in January–February 2026 continued to show a competitive but generally No-leaning field; recent What Scotland Thinks entries record No ahead of Yes in major polls.
Source: What Scotland Thinks / YouGov / Survation.
Type: cultural / quantitative. **Signal 11: Institutional trust and competence.**
Description: Ipsos found in February 2026 that 68% of Britons lacked confidence in the government's integrity and 69% lacked confidence in its competence; in late 2025 only 9% said politicians generally tell the truth.
Source: Ipsos Political Pulse; Ipsos Veracity Index.
Type: cultural / quantitative. **Signal 12: Manufacturing performance.**
Description: UK manufacturers' product sales were £452.2 billion in 2024, down 3.1% from 2023; manufacturing output in the three months to December 2025 was up 0.3% year-on-year, but monthly output fell 0.5% in December 2025.
Source: ONS; House of Commons Library.
Type: quantitative / sectoral.

Signal 13: Services performance.
Description: Services output in Q4 2025 showed no growth relative to Q3 2025; services remain around 79% of GDP.
Source: ONS Index of Services.
Type: quantitative / sectoral.

Signal 14: Regulatory divergence.
Description: UK in a Changing Europe's Q4 2025 tracker identified 19 cases of passive divergence and 8 of active divergence between UK and EU rules; other trackers note that by end-2025 nearly 40% of tracked retained EU laws had been reformed.
Source: UK in a Changing Europe; divergence tracking summaries.
Type: institutional / regulatory. **Signal 15: Identity and Brexit opinion.**
Description: NatCen found strong links between Brexit preference and concepts of national identity; YouGov in June 2025 found 56% said it was wrong to leave the EU.
Source: British Social Attitudes / NatCen; YouGov.
Type: cultural / attitudinal.

Counter-signals

Counter-signal A: GDP still grows.
Despite Brexit-drag arguments, headline GDP was still growing in late 2025, complicating any simple collapse narrative.

Counter-signal B: Non-EU migration remained large even after free movement ended.
For sovereigntist closure, border "control" did not produce low migration in aggregate; it changed composition. **Counter-signal C: Regulatory divergence remains limited and uneven.**
For maximal-sovereignty narratives, divergence is real but often partial, passive, or constrained by the Trade and Cooperation Agreement and economic interdependence. **Counter-signal D: Public regret over Brexit does not automatically translate into a re-entry consensus under full EU terms.**
Many Britons favour closer ties or even rejoining in the abstract, but support falls when euro, Schengen, or opt-out loss is specified.

3. Grammar Specifications

Grammar 1: Sovereigntist Democratic Recovery

Primary analytical variable: restoration of self-government and democratic decision-making authority.

Signal selection rules: admits signals that speak to legal autonomy, border control, legislative freedom, treaty independence, electoral mandate, and the principle that decisions binding the polity should be made by accountable domestic institutions.

Weighting priority: constitutional authority outranks efficiency; democratic control outranks frictional cost; symbolic recovery of agency outranks aggregate welfare metrics.

Causal chain type: moral-constitutional and rights-based, with secondary institutional causation.

Admissible closure: Brexit is justified if it restored the capacity of the British demos to govern itself, even at measurable economic cost.

Excluded signals: counterfactual macroeconomic loss estimates treated as speculative; elite regret polling treated as post hoc; supranational efficiency claims demoted if they override democratic self-rule.

Characteristic vocabulary: sovereignty, mandate, self-government, democratic deficit, taking back control, accountability, legal autonomy, border integrity, national interest.

Source tradition: constitutional sovereigntism, democratic populism, parts of conservative Euroscepticism, republican arguments about non-domination by external rule.

Grammar 2: Economic-Administrative Interdependence

Primary analytical variable: the efficiency and welfare effects of institutional integration and frictionless exchange.

Signal selection rules: admits GDP, productivity, trade intensity, sectoral performance, regulatory cost, administrative burden, investment confidence, border friction, labour supply, and institutional trust where competence affects performance.

Weighting priority: long-run productivity and trade structure outrank symbolic claims; systemic interdependence outranks singular acts of mandate.

Causal chain type: systemic-causal, institutional-economic, path-dependent.

Admissible closure: Brexit is judged by whether disintegration from the EU reduced growth, trade efficiency, state capacity, and long-run productivity relative to feasible alternatives.

Excluded signals: pure sovereignty claims without material effect; romantic national agency narratives; cultural affirmation that cannot be translated into institutional performance.

Characteristic vocabulary: frictions, non-tariff barriers, productivity drag, market access, regulatory alignment, business certainty, supply chains, implementation costs, institutional settlement.

Source tradition: mainstream economics, public administration, business policy analysis, centre-state institutionalism, liberal interdependence.

Grammar 3: Class-Recomposition and Uneven Britain

Primary analytical variable: how Brexit expresses and reorganises unequal social blocs, territorial grievances, labour-market restructuring, and status conflict inside Britain.

Signal selection rules: admits regional cleavage, class patterning, trust collapse, identity formation, migration narratives, sectoral unevenness, territorial constitutional stress, and the distributive consequences of trade and labour policy.

Weighting priority: who benefits and who absorbs the cost outranks aggregate national averages; social meaning and political realignment outrank narrow legal doctrine.

Causal chain type: political-economic and socio-cultural, mediated by institutions and identity.

Admissible closure: Brexit is neither simply liberation nor simply error; it is a displaced settlement of deep inequalities, processed through nationalist language and then redistributed unevenly across classes, places, and nations within the UK.

Excluded signals: abstract constitutional triumphalism detached from social base; national GDP aggregates that hide regional and class differentiation.

Characteristic vocabulary: left behind, uneven development, grievance, bloc formation, social base, territorial strain, elite mediation, distributional settlement, cultural cleavage.

Source tradition: political economy, class analysis, regional inequality research, cultural sociology of status conflict, post-industrial cleavage literature.

4. Signal Processing

Grammar 1 Essay: Sovereigntist Democratic Recovery

The primary variable in this grammar is **self-government**. Brexit is first and last about who rules. The referendum result is not merely one datum among others; it is the constitutive signal from which the rest of the chain derives. The 51.9% Leave vote established a democratic mandate to remove the UK from a supranational order in which binding rules were made through institutions the British electorate could influence only indirectly. That result therefore carries constitutional weight beyond its margin. In this grammar, critics who reduce Brexit to a narrow 52–48 split misunderstand the nature of democratic authorization: a mandate is not invalid because it is contested; democratic decisions are often close.

From that starting point, the relevant question becomes whether Brexit restored the capacity of British institutions to legislate, regulate, and negotiate in the national interest. The existence of post-Brexit regulatory divergence matters here not because every divergence is economically optimal, but because divergence demonstrates recovered jurisdiction. UK in a Changing Europe's tracker records both active and passive divergence, and the broader retained-EU-law reform record shows that a substantial body of inherited law has been reworked. That is meaningful not as bureaucratic tidying but as evidence that the locus of authority has shifted. The right to decide differently is the substance of sovereignty, even where the decision is to remain aligned. Trade figures are admissible, but only secondarily. The EU remained a major trade partner in 2024, accounting for 41% of exports and 51% of imports. For this grammar, that does not prove that political subordination should continue; it proves that geography still matters. Likewise, the December 2025 pattern in which exports to the EU were lower than to non-EU countries while imports from the EU remained higher can be read not simply as damage but as transitional rebalancing in a large economy redefining its commercial posture. What matters is that trade policy is now under domestic democratic control. Economic exchange should be a tool of self-government, not a reason to dissolve it. Immigration data carry greater weight because control of borders was central to the democratic claim. Here the evidence is mixed but still intelligible within the grammar. ONS figures show that by YE June 2025 EU+ net migration had fallen to -70,000, continuing a downward trend from the referendum and through the end of free movement. That is a major institutional change: one route of externalised labour mobility has been politically reversed. The fact that non-EU+ net migration remained positive at +383,000, and total immigration was still 898,000, is a tension, but not a refutation. Sovereignty means the right to choose admissions criteria, not the guarantee of low flows. A state may decide that some forms of migration better fit labour-market and public-interest priorities than automatic free movement. In this grammar, composition matters more than totality: policy discretion has replaced treaty obligation. Northern Ireland is processed as the hardest test of post-Brexit sovereignty. The original Protocol exposed a constitutional wound by placing internal UK trade under arrangements shaped by the need to avoid a hard border on the island of Ireland. The Windsor Framework is therefore read as an attempt to repair a settlement that had compromised the Union and produced a "democratic deficit" for Northern Ireland. Its green-lane arrangements, medicines solution, and phased implementation into 2025 matter because they reduce unnecessary internal-market disruption while preserving peace commitments. This grammar does not celebrate the Framework as ideal; it treats it as corrective statecraft made necessary by the complexity of exit. Sovereignty here is not purity. It

is the ongoing work of restoring domestic constitutional coherence under difficult inherited constraints. GDP and productivity claims are admitted cautiously. The OBR's 4% long-run productivity-drag assumption is not ignored, but it is demoted because it is a modelled counterfactual rather than an observed constitutional fact. The UK economy continued to grow in late 2025. That growth does not prove Brexit an economic success, but it does show that predictions of immediate ruin were overstated. More importantly, this grammar denies that prosperity estimates can settle the legitimacy question. A polity may rationally accept some efficiency loss in exchange for restored rule-making autonomy. Democratic peoples are not corporations optimizing throughput. Institutional trust is likewise interpreted differently. Ipsos found very low trust in politicians and government competence by 2025–26. A sovereigntist grammar can absorb this by arguing that distrust belongs not to Brexit as such but to the class of political managers who delayed, diluted, or mis-implemented the mandate. On this reading, failure of execution is not failure of principle. The complaint becomes: Brexit was not betrayed by the electorate's choice, but by an elite apparatus reluctant to honor it cleanly. Low trust therefore intensifies rather than negates the demand for accountable national self-government. Scottish independence polling and wider identity data create further tension. NatCen shows that Brexit is entangled with different conceptions of national identity, and Scottish polling shows continuing constitutional strain. This grammar typically answers that democratic authority must still reside somewhere, and that fragmenting authority upward to the EU and downward to secessionist projects cannot be the solution to every disagreement. The Union, on this view, is the primary democratic vessel that must be defended and re-legitimated. Brexit exposed internal fractures, but those fractures predated Brexit and cannot be solved by surrendering UK-wide self-rule to a larger bloc. **Internal counterpoint.** The strongest admissible complications are the persistence of high aggregate migration and the need for the 2025 UK-EU reset. If sovereignty were fully secured, why negotiate closer cooperation on SPS, ETS linkage, Erasmus+, or electricity? The answer this grammar gives is that sovereign states cooperate all the time. Re-engagement is not subordination so long as domestic institutions retain the final authority to consent. Similarly, high non-EU migration may look like failure to voters who associated Brexit with lower overall numbers, and this grammar struggles here because public expectations were not only constitutional but practical. Still, it can maintain that controlled discretion, not numeric minimalism, is the core gain.

Closure statement.
Processed through the sovereigntist democratic-recovery grammar, Brexit remains fundamentally justified: it restored the principle that the UK should be governed by institutions answerable to its own electorate, even if implementation has been imperfect and even if autonomy carries costs. That closure is produced by this grammar's constitutional weighting, not by a neutral final verdict on reality.

Grammar 2 Essay: Economic-Administrative Interdependence

The primary variable here is **institutional interdependence**. Brexit is processed not as an abstract referendum mandate but as a reconfiguration of the economic and administrative architecture through which a highly integrated economy functioned. The central question is straightforward: did exit from the single market and customs union increase frictions, reduce efficiency, lower productivity, and impose recurring governance costs? In this grammar, the answer begins not with 2016 symbolism but with the observable and modelled effects of disintegration from a dense regional institutional order.

The referendum result is still a signal, but it is not dispositive. A democratic mandate can authorize a policy and still authorize a mistake. The narrowness of the 52–48 split matters here because it indicates that the constitutional act was undertaken without durable consensus despite exceptionally high stakes for trade, investment, regulation, and territorial settlement. That does not invalidate the vote. It increases the burden of performance placed on the post-referendum settlement. Once performance becomes the test, the signal hierarchy changes sharply. The most heavily weighted signal is the OBR's continued assumption that the post-Brexit trading relationship reduces long-run productivity by 4% relative to remaining in the EU. In this grammar, such model-based institutional analysis matters precisely because the true counterfactual cannot be observed directly. The mechanism is clear: additional non-tariff barriers impede comparative advantage,

reduce trade intensity, weaken competitive pressure, and lower productivity over time. This is not a moral judgment but a structural one. A modern economy like the UK's does not simply "trade less efficiently" in a narrow sense when integration is reduced; it reallocates managerial effort into compliance, duplication, and risk absorption. Trade data reinforce the diagnosis. The House of Commons Library notes that the EU remained by far the UK's largest trade partner in 2024, taking 41% of exports and supplying 51% of imports. This alone makes deep economic detachment costly. December 2025 ONS data show that imports from the EU were still higher than imports from non-EU countries, while exports to the EU were lower than to non-EU markets. That is not evidence of successful global substitution. It is evidence of an economy still deeply dependent on European supply and demand while facing higher transactional friction in the relationship that matters most. Geography, standards, logistics, and just-in-time production do not disappear because political rhetoric invokes "Global Britain." Sectoral performance fits the same pattern. Manufacturing sales fell 3.1% in 2024, and manufacturing output was only marginally up year-on-year by late 2025, with monthly volatility continuing. Services output in Q4 2025 was flat. No serious analyst would attribute all this to Brexit; the pandemic, energy shocks, and global politics matter. But that is exactly why this grammar privileges comparative and institutional evidence over headline growth snapshots. The question is whether the UK has outperformed what would have been feasible with lower trade frictions and more predictable regulatory relations. The answer suggested by the long-run productivity assumption and trade-intensity evidence is no. Migration is interpreted through labour supply and system design rather than symbolic control. The end of free movement sharply reduced EU migration, with EU+ net migration at -70,000 in YE June 2025 and EU inflows far below 2016 levels. But aggregate migration did not collapse; non-EU+ net migration remained +383,000 and total immigration 898,000. This suggests substitution rather than resolution. The UK replaced a geographically proximate, rights-bearing labour regime with a more heavily visa-mediated, administratively managed system. From an interdependence perspective, this may increase transaction costs for employers, reduce flexibility in sectors previously reliant on EU labour, and undermine some of the supposed gains of "control." Northern Ireland offers especially strong evidence for this grammar because it reveals the cost of trying to leave one institutional system while keeping open a politically indispensable border. The original Protocol and then the Windsor Framework were not incidental; they were generated by the irreducible contradiction between territorial peace obligations, integrated trade, and the desire for legal separation. The need for green lanes, customs redesign, medicines exceptions, and continuing review mechanisms demonstrates that dense integration had to be partially reconstructed after political exit. The system keeps generating repair work because the underlying interdependence never vanished. Regulatory divergence strengthens rather than weakens this conclusion. UK in a Changing Europe recorded active and passive divergence through Q4 2025, but the point is not that divergence is impossible; it is that divergence itself carries management costs. Where standards split, firms trading across borders must absorb duplication. Where the UK remains aligned informally, the sovereignty gain is thinner than advertised. Where the UK diverges, business friction grows. This is the basic institutional trap: high-alignment sectors preserve market access but dilute autonomy; high-divergence sectors dramatize autonomy but raise costs. The 2025 UK-EU summit and subsequent work on SPS, ETS linkage, electricity, and Erasmus+ are therefore not signs of post-Brexit optional cooperation. They are signs that the system is bending back toward functional coordination. Institutional trust matters here because low confidence in governmental competence amplifies the damage from administratively complex arrangements. Ipsos reported that roughly seven in ten Britons lacked confidence in the government's competence or integrity in February 2026. In a highly technical post-Brexit settlement, low-trust governance is especially costly. Businesses and citizens must rely on stable rule interpretation, capable border management, and credible long-term signalling. When political institutions are distrusted, the administrative burden of a friction-heavy system becomes harder to manage. Scottish constitutional strain and broader public regret also fit the same picture. Polling shows a sustained No lead but an enduring independence cleavage, while YouGov found in June 2025 that 56% thought it was wrong to leave the EU. In this grammar, these are not merely emotional after-effects. They are signals that Brexit weakened the legitimacy of the broader settlement by imposing a costly institutional redesign that remains socially and territorially contested. **Internal counterpoint.**

Two admissible tensions complicate this closure. First, headline GDP was still growing in late 2025. Second, the economy did not experience the catastrophic immediate collapse predicted by some campaign

rhetoric. This grammar accommodates those points by distinguishing between growth and lost growth, and between collapse narratives and friction narratives. A country can continue to grow while still underperforming a better integrated counterfactual. The absence of catastrophe does not imply the absence of structural loss.

Closure statement.
Processed through the economic-administrative interdependence grammar, Brexit is a self-imposed institutional disintegration that has lowered the efficiency of the UK's principal economic relationships, generated persistent governance repair, and left the state seeking piecemeal re-coordination with the very system it exited. That closure is produced by this grammar's weighting of performance, friction, and interdependence, not by a universal final judgment.

Grammar 3 Essay: Class-Recomposition and Uneven Britain

The primary variable in this grammar is **uneven social settlement**. Brexit is not treated mainly as a constitutional question or a market-efficiency question, though it contains both. It is processed as a political form through which long-standing inequalities, status injuries, territorial asymmetries, and institutional distrust were expressed, mobilised, and then redistributed. The referendum result matters because it condensed multiple grievances into one vote. A 51.9% Leave result did not simply say "leave the EU"; it bound together deindustrialised places, anti-elite sentiment, identity anxiety, constitutional conservatism, and hopes for recovery that were never socially uniform.

This grammar therefore begins by refusing the national-average illusion. GDP growth in Q4 2025 or an OBR long-run productivity loss estimate are relevant, but neither tells us which sectors, regions, or blocs are carrying the consequences. The OBR's 4% long-run productivity assumption still matters because lower productivity is not socially neutral: it constrains wages, fiscal room, public services, and investment capacity. But the key analytic move is to ask where those pressures land and how they are narrated back into politics. Trade signals are interpreted similarly. The EU remained the UK's main partner in 2024. That fact means Brexit reshaped the commercial environment of the places and industries most entangled with European markets. If agrifood exporters, manufacturers, logistics chains, and border-facing firms absorb greater frictions, the effects are unlikely to distribute evenly across London, ex-industrial towns, Northern Ireland, or export-oriented regions. December 2025 trade data showing EU imports still outstripping non-EU imports and EU exports lagging non-EU exports suggest not simply "less trade" but a more uneven burden of adaptation. Some firms can redirect, lawyer up, digitise compliance, or hedge. Smaller businesses and weaker regions usually cannot do so as easily. Migration data become especially revealing in this grammar because Brexit's politics often fused labour competition, public-service pressure, and cultural boundary-making. Yet the post-Brexit result was not simple closure. EU migration fell sharply and turned negative on a net basis, but non-EU migration remained substantial. That means the social meaning of Brexit and its policy output diverged. Voters in some places may have expected lower migration overall or a re-prioritisation of local labour and services; instead, the labour market was reconfigured. The grammar's point is not that one migration profile is objectively better than another. It is that a promise encoded as democratic recovery translated into a different social composition of mobility rather than a disappearance of dependency on migrant labour. That gap between symbolic resolution and lived outcome is politically generative. Institutional trust is weighted heavily because it reveals the social atmosphere in which Brexit continues to be interpreted. Ipsos found extremely low confidence in political competence and honesty. NatCen likewise reports a wider decline in trust and confidence in governing arrangements. In this grammar, that distrust is not an incidental mood variable. It is the medium through which Brexit is continually reclassified. Where trust is low, failed promises are remembered as betrayal, compromise appears as elite stitch-up, and technocratic repair is easily read as democratic evasion. That is why the same UK-EU "reset" can appear to one constituency as sensible pragmatism and to another as the slow reversal of a popular mandate. Northern Ireland and Scotland are processed not as side questions but as evidence that Brexit intensified the uneven constitutional geography of the UK. The Windsor Framework

shows that one part of the state required bespoke arrangements because the aggregate national choice could not be territorially implemented without destabilising peace and trade. In Scotland, persistent independence contention shows that Brexit reactivated the question of which demos counts: British, Scottish, or European. NatCen's work on national identity is critical here because it shows that Brexit and Scottish independence draw on different nationalisms, not a single common sovereignty impulse. In other words, Brexit did not merely restore one national will. It exposed that the UK houses competing political communities with distinct identity structures and different interpretations of legitimacy. Manufacturing and services signals reinforce the uneven-development frame. Manufacturing sales fell in 2024 and output remained fragile into late 2025; services, which dominate the national economy, were flat in Q4 2025. Aggregate statistics hide sectoral composition. Post-industrial and trade-exposed localities do not experience these shifts in the same way as globally networked service centres. The Brexit coalition was partly built on regions that felt bypassed by the gains of pre-2016 integration. If the post-Brexit settlement then reproduces weak productivity, stagnant services, and selective sectoral stress, the original grievance may persist under a different ideological label. Brexit becomes less a solved question than a new container for unresolved inequality. Identity polling sharpens the point. NatCen found that Brexit preference is strongly related to conceptions of who counts as truly British, while YouGov found that by mid-2025 a majority thought it was wrong to leave the EU. This grammar resists treating either statistic as mere opinion swing. Instead it asks how social blocs are reassembled. Some Leave-aligned identities remain attached to sovereignty language even when dissatisfied with outcomes; some Remain or Rejoin sentiment reflects not only economic disappointment but also generational, educational, metropolitan, and cosmopolitan alignment. Brexit's afterlife is therefore an ongoing recomposition of class, identity, and territorial politics, not just a verdict on a treaty choice. The 2025 UK-EU summit further illustrates elite mediation of a deeper social problem. The summit's strategic partnership, and the later work on Erasmus+, SPS, ETS linkage, and electricity, show that governing elites are trying to reduce the material damage and symbolic toxicity of the post-2016 settlement without reopening the foundational constitutional conflict. In this grammar, that is classic elite management: recalibrate the regime, soften the costs, avoid refighting the bloc-defining vote, and hope the electorate accepts partial normalisation. But because Brexit originated in a crisis of representation, managerial repair may stabilise the system materially while deepening cynicism politically.

Internal counterpoint.

This grammar must reckon with two tensions. First, it can over-socialise everything, reducing genuine constitutional belief or sincere economic argument to mere expressions of class position. Second, it risks underestimating the real normative appeal of self-government. Some voters did in fact care about sovereignty as principle, not just as a vehicle for grievance. Likewise, some economic losses are real enough that they cannot be dissolved into symbolic politics alone. The grammar accommodates this by treating sovereignty and efficiency as real vocabularies through which social blocs organise, not as pure illusions.

Closure statement.

Processed through the class-recomposition and uneven-Britain grammar, Brexit is best understood as a displaced settlement of long-building inequalities and identity fractures, expressed through a sovereignty vote and then redistributed unevenly through trade, migration, trust, and constitutional strain. That closure is a product of this grammar's social-distributional weighting, not a final neutral account of reality.

5. Closure Comparison

The sharpest divergence lies in the **status of the referendum mandate**, the **meaning of migration change**, and the **interpretation of institutional repair**. For the sovereigntist grammar, the referendum is constitutive and normatively primary; for the interdependence grammar, it authorizes a policy whose performance must then be judged materially; for the class-recomposition grammar, it is a condensation event that translated multiple grievances into one constitutional act. The same 52–48 signal therefore

generates three different chains: legitimacy restored, costly misalignment, or social fracture expressed through national choice.

Migration produces especially strong divergence. The sovereigntist grammar foregrounds the end of free movement and treats the fall in EU migration as proof of regained discretion. The interdependence grammar sees substitution toward a more cumbersome non-EU system and asks what this does to labour supply and administrative burden. The class grammar reads the pattern as a mismatch between symbolic promises and socially lived outcomes. The raw numbers are shared; the meaning of “control” is not. The Windsor Framework and later UK-EU reset also divide the grammars. In grammar one, they are pragmatic sovereign statecraft: cooperation after exit. In grammar two, they are evidence that interdependence keeps forcing partial reintegration. In grammar three, they are elite-managed repair of a settlement that remains socially unresolved. Here the divergence is chiefly about causation and prescription rather than raw fact. All three can see the same agreements. They disagree on what those agreements reveal. There is some convergence. All three grammars can admit that Brexit did not end the UK-EU relationship; it transformed it into a more complex and negotiated one. All three can also acknowledge that the Northern Ireland question exposed the difficulty of implementing a territorially uniform exit. Likewise, each grammar can see that public trust is low, though it assigns the cause differently. What each grammar excludes is instructive. The sovereigntist grammar suppresses counterfactual performance analysis when it threatens constitutional closure. The interdependence grammar suppresses the irreducibly normative claim that self-government may justify cost. The class grammar suppresses the possibility that constitutional principle and economic reasoning can sometimes be sincere primary drivers rather than masks for social location. The pattern of divergence is therefore not just about facts. It is about **causal hierarchy**, **normative priority**, and **what counts as a valid ending**. Facts are shared only at the input stage. At the output stage, the contest is over what the facts are allowed to mean.

6. Counter-Signal Analysis and Leakage

Sovereigntist Democratic Recovery

The most threatening counter-signals are high non-EU migration and the need for renewed UK-EU coordination in 2025–26. These threaten the closure because they suggest that neither borders nor regulatory life became as autonomous as promised. Leakage appears when sovereigntist arguments borrow economic language about growth, business benefit, or smoother trade to defend Brexit’s success. Once sovereignty advocates begin justifying Brexit by forecast GDP gains or export opportunities, they have partly entered the interdependence grammar’s terrain.

Economic-Administrative Interdependence

Its strongest counter-signals are continued GDP growth and the absence of an immediate macroeconomic collapse. These do not destroy the grammar, but they force it onto counterfactual reasoning and away from simple observation. Leakage occurs when institutional-economic critics appeal to public regret, democratic imprudence, or national self-harm in moralised language. At that point, they are borrowing from neighbouring moral-political grammars rather than staying within performance analysis.

Class-Recomposition and Uneven Britain

Its main threats are genuinely principled sovereignty commitments and robust macro-institutional evidence that cannot be reduced to bloc expression. Leakage occurs when class analysis starts speaking as though a national productivity loss automatically settles the political meaning of Brexit, or when it treats sovereignty

language as nothing but elite manipulation. In both cases, it borrows too much either from economic-institutional closure or from a cynical reductionism that cannot account for sincere constitutional belief.

7. Reflexive Note

The grammar that felt most natural to produce was the **economic-administrative interdependence** grammar, probably because official datasets, institutional reports, and causal chains are especially well structured in that mode. The grammar that felt most difficult was the **sovereigntist democratic-recovery** grammar, not because it lacks coherence, but because it requires giving constitutional principle priority over signals that contemporary analytic culture often treats as dispositive. Had the whole exercise been conducted from within the sovereigntist grammar alone, much of the economic evidence would have appeared secondary or mis-specified from the start; from within the class grammar, the same evidence would have been redistributed across blocs and territories rather than read at the national aggregate level. The exercise shows that interpretive architectures do not merely bias conclusions at the margins. They define what the phenomenon is, which injuries matter, what counts as proof, and which endings are even thinkable.

8. Methodological Observations

What worked best in the procedure was the forced separation between **signal field** and **processing architecture**. Holding the signals relatively constant made it easier to see that divergence was not mostly generated by “different facts” but by different ranking rules, causal templates, and admissible closures. The method is especially strong where public controversies repeatedly accuse opponents of bad faith or ignorance; it demonstrates that many disagreements are structurally produced.

The main difficulty was that some signals are not fully neutral. A referendum result, for example, is both a datum and a normatively loaded event. Likewise, an OBR counterfactual is not just “a fact”; it is a modelled institutional judgment. More guidance on how to classify mixed signals would help. It would also help to distinguish more explicitly between **event-signals**, **performance-signals**, and **identity-signals**, because they behave differently in processing.

A further ambiguity concerns scale. National GDP, territorial politics, and household-level social meaning sit at different levels of analysis. Some grammars naturally privilege one scale over another. The method could be refined by adding a sixth parameter to each grammar card: **preferred scale of resolution**. Another useful refinement would be a short rule for handling counterfactuals, since many contemporary disputes rely on estimates of foregone outcomes rather than directly observable loss.

Overall, the method is very effective. Its main value is not that it eliminates disagreement, but that it makes the architecture of disagreement inspectable.